



THE REEL CIVIL WAR

Mythmaking in American Film

BRUCE CHADWICK

"Chadwick's dissection of the myths [these movies] helped to foster is superb. . . . [An] enlightening volume." —*The New York Times Book Review*

The War Comes to Tara

ATLANTA, GEORGIA, December 15, 1939: If the South had won the Civil War in a replay, Atlanta could not have been in a more celebratory mood than on this night, the night of the premiere of *Gone With the Wind*. Over seven hundred thousand visitors had booked hotel rooms throughout the city and in small towns as far as thirty miles away. Huge searchlights in front of the Grand Theatre, the site of the premiere, were so powerful that their beams scanning the sky in lazy circles could be seen as far as Macon, fifty miles away.

The excitement had been building for weeks. The governor of Georgia had proclaimed the day of the premiere a state holiday¹ and earlier in the week had waited at the airport, with other dignitaries, to meet planes carrying Clark Gable (who flew on the MGM plane, which had GONE WITH THE WIND painted in huge letters on its side), Vivien Leigh and producer David O. Selznick (Leigh's plane was kept circling Atlanta for forty-five minutes because the flowers the mayor of Atlanta was to present her were late). Thousands of citizens rented 1860s-style hoopskirts and suits for the occasion. Dozens of local department stores proudly displayed in their windows costumes from the movie, loaned by the studio. The governors of seven states were in attendance. Political notables such as W. Averell Harri-man and Herbert Hoover mingled with celebrities Billy Rose, Carole Lombard, Laurence Olivier and a host of MGM stars.

At the Grand Theatre, there was chaos. The building's entire front had been remade into a replica of Scarlett O'Hara's plantation mansion, Tara, complete with white columns. The twenty-five hundred tickets, usually fifty cents but hiked to ten dollars for the premiere,

had been sold out for months. On this, the climactic night, scalpers were getting more than two hundred dollars a ticket.²

The stars arrived in a long parade of convertibles as thousands of fans lining the streets cheered wildly. Everyone connected with the film in a major way was in Atlanta and in the parade except director Victor Fleming, who was feuding with Selznick. British actress Vivien Leigh, who played Scarlett, the everlasting symbol of Southern womanhood, in fact knew very little about Southern cultural traditions. As she rode along in her convertible, she kept hearing bands play "Dixie." She turned to the man next to her and gushingly told him that she thought it was a good omen for the success of *Gone With the Wind* that people were already playing its music.³

The night before the premiere, the stars had appeared at a Junior League ball. (Margaret Mitchell did not attend because the Junior League had snubbed her years before.) There were so many people who wanted to get in that a second ball was held down the street in a hotel. At the ball, Clark Gable danced with the daughter of the mayor of Atlanta and, one reveler reported, caused a local debutante to faint when he asked her to dance.

The jockeying for tickets to the premiere had gone on for months. Feuds erupted at Macmillan, publisher of the novel, when it was learned that the company was limited to six tickets. The head of the Atlanta chapter of the Daughters of the American Revolution became involved in a dispute with producers over complimentary tickets. After listening to her harangue at some length, an assistant producer snapped, "Wrong war!"

Studio moguls pulled out all the stops, sending a team of publicists to Atlanta to handle that opening and other publicists to other cities to prepare their premieres. Special programs were printed for the Atlanta opener. Selznick, always a stickler for detail, warned the printers not to make the program paper too crisp: he was afraid that as the pages were turned during the movie the crackling sound would drown out the dialogue. Also, knowing that huge crowds of spectators would be present, he was nervous about the publicity shots of the stars—the photos traditionally sent out by the studios; he was worried lest people in the crowds get into the background, and so he dispatched photographers to Atlanta well in advance to photograph the front of the theater, with its Tara façade, and had them send the pho-

tos back to Hollywood. The stars were then photographed alone, in Hollywood, and studio magicians superimposed these pictures over the Atlanta photos so they looked as though they had been shot at the premiere.

The audience in the Grand Theatre was hushed when Max Steiner's lush theme started to play and the film began, but the hush didn't last long. People wept at the scene in which thousands of Confederate soldiers lie wounded in an Atlanta square, roared their approval when Scarlett shoots a Yankee soldier and clapped their hands and sang whenever any ragtag band in the movie struck up "Dixie."⁴



*A tense Scarlett, revolver in hand, just before she shoots and kills a Union soldier who seems intent on raping her. Audiences at the Atlanta premiere of *Gone With the Wind* cheered when she killed the man.*

In retrospect, of course, it's clear that the movie could not miss: it was based on a number one best-selling book, it had a stellar cast and it was one of the first great technicolor extravaganzas. However, in the beginning Selznick had thought the movie a risky project. He had

paid a record amount of money for the book rights, and he knew that production would be extremely expensive and that it would take a long time to shoot. The film would also be facing strong competition from the hundreds of other movies released in 1939. He did not know whom to sign on as chief screenwriter and was uncertain about his original choice for director, George Cukor.

To insure his investment he borrowed box office champion Clark Gable from MGM and agreed to pay his hefty salary of forty-three hundred dollars a week. Everyone told him Gable was perfect to play Rhett Butler and Hollywood columnists were so certain of the match that, writing about the casting of *Gone With the Wind*, some asked rhetorically in their columns, "Who will play Clark Gable?"

Gable, ironically, had no faith in the film's prospects, and did not want the part. "I didn't want [it] for money, chalk or marbles," he said later. He had to be talked into it. Then he had to be talked into crying on screen in the scene where he believes Scarlett is going to die. He had never cried before in a film, and he was certain it would ruin his masculine image. But his tears not only did not undermine his masculinity, they made him even more of a superstar.⁵ One thing he was adamant about, however, was his refusal to take speech lessons in order to speak with a Southern accent. It turned out not to matter, and he came out of the movie as the matinee idol of all time.

The most sensual scene of the film, of course, is when Rhett picks up Scarlett against her will and carries her up the enormous, wide, darkened staircase towards the bedroom. It was considered one of the most erotic scenes of all time—although some women complained that what he did was rape. Actually, Gable and Leigh couldn't get the scene right and it had to be reshot twelve different times. Each time, Gable had to carry the actress in his arms up that long flight of stairs. After the final take, Gable was completely drained physically and had to rest. He could not have made it up the stairs one more time, much less raped anybody.⁶

The search to find an actress to play Scarlett (she was named Pansy O'Hara in the first draft of the book, but someone wisely persuaded the author to change the name), a public relations masterstroke, took two years. Just about every top star in Hollywood, as well as hundreds of unknowns from coast to coast, auditioned for the role. (A rumor started, never completely quieted, that when Selznick learned how

much the production, plus Gable's salary, would cost, he decided to cast unknowns as Scarlett and Melanie just to save money.)⁷ No one was signed. Selznick searched and his aides searched. They ran auditions in every major American city and sent scouts to small ones. They looked throughout the United States, Mexico and Canada. But always the women were too old or too young, too heavy or too thin.

Finally, having given up, and under enormous pressure to begin filming, Selznick decided to start shooting around the star. He climbed to the top of a high wooden tower one night in Hollywood to supervise the burning down of a studio set that on film would be the burning of Atlanta. Hundreds of people—cast, crew and firemen—stood around watching the enormous conflagration, which could be seen as far away as Santa Monica. At the very height of the blaze, as flames leaped into the Los Angeles sky and the heat became intense, Selznick heard the sound of feet climbing the ladder of the tower behind him. This was followed by the familiar voice of his brother Myron, an agent. The producer turned and, squinting because of the heat from the fire, looked directly across the platform at one of the most beautiful women he had ever seen—Vivien Leigh.

"David," said his brother, "I'd like you to meet Scarlett O'Hara."

GONE WITH THE WIND became one of the most successful movies of all time, earning over \$60 million in box office receipts (close to \$1 billion in today's money), and was seen by millions of Americans in its various television showings. It was estimated that between its first theater showing in 1939 and 1945 more than 120 million Americans, or just about every adult in the country, saw it. Many theaters ran it for a year; a number in the South had ushers dress as Confederate officers and Southern belles. There was such demand to see the movie that distributors gave up their restrictions and permitted more than one first-run movie theater in a city to show it. In New York City, the Empire, Ritz and Palace, all ornate first-run houses, showcased it for twelve months.⁸ It ran for two years in Atlanta. A movie house in London showed it for four straight years. Demand for tickets was so great in some towns that theaters doubled prices and some added a second or third showing each day. In some markets, the movie was yanked from houses after six months to build demand from those who hadn't

yet had a chance to see it, held in Hollywood for a time, and then rereleased to a second wave of ticket-buying madness. It was rereleased several times over the years 1940–45. Each time it got new reviews that helped to stimulate new box office records.⁹

It also stirred up controversy with both Northern and Southern commemorative groups.

In the South, the search for Scarlett caused an uproar. Several chapters of the Daughters of the Confederacy threatened to boycott the film because an English actress landed the role. Indignation grew so intense that it spilled over onto the floor of the Daughters' national convention. Peace finally came when the group's president-general, Mrs. Walter LaMar, assured the ladies that as a world traveler she had met many British women and found them "most delightful."¹⁰

In the North, members of the Daughters of Union Veterans complained that the film wrecked the reputation of General Sherman, insinuated that all Union soldiers tried to rape Southern women and misrepresented the story of the war. "It is unfair that our boys and girls should be given such a distorted view of what actually took place," stated a resolution drafted by the group and read by a member at one of their meetings.¹¹

GWTW broke other ground. Producer Selznick paid a then-record \$50,000 for the rights to Margaret Mitchell's novel. It was the costliest movie made until that time, at \$4.25 million, and also the most lavish. Selznick shot over 450,000 feet of film in order to edit it down to a final version of 19,980 feet. The producer had fifteen hundred scene sketches drawn, ordered two hundred sets designed and actually built ninety (including the old studio lot that he burned). He hired a cast of more than twenty-four hundred people; designers produced fifty-five hundred costumes.¹²

Along with *The Wizard of Oz*, GWTW was one of the handful of experimental color films of the later 1930s (only ten were made in 1939). One major reason that Selznick spent so lavishly on color was that Jock Whitney, one of moviedom's biggest investors, and one of GWTW's largest financial backers, had invested in some of the early color movies of 1937 and 1938, such as *Nothing Sacred*, *Tom Sawyer* and *A Star Is Born*. Whitney was also a major investor in the company that produced Technicolor film and he pushed Selznick hard to make GWTW a guinea pig for the new process.¹³ If *Gone With the Wind*

had been filmed in black-and-white, its impact, then and later, would have been significantly less. It was a long movie, nearly four hours, in an era of ninety-minute to two-hour features, and, like *The Birth of a Nation*, it showed Hollywood that long movies could succeed at the box office. The film made Vivien Leigh a star, and Clark Gable a legend. (Twenty-eight years later, in 1967, when the movie was rereleased, many audiences broke into sustained applause at the point when he appears for the first time, at the foot of the staircase at the Wilkes party. A whole new generation of young women swooned as their mothers had years before at first sight of him.)¹⁴

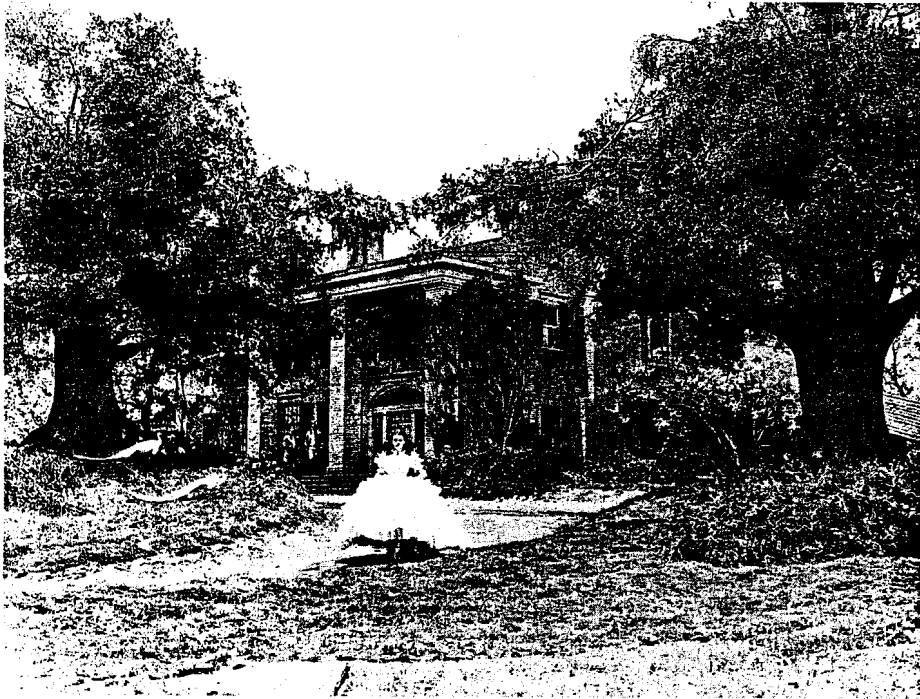
Most critics enjoyed *Gone With the Wind*. But some, like Lincoln Kirstein, in *Film Magazine*, saw its historical flaws. He wrote: "History has rarely been told with even an approximation of truth in Hollywood because the few men in control there have no interest in the real forces behind historical movements and the new forces that every new epoch sets in motion. *Gone With the Wind* deserves our attention because it is an overinflated example of the usual false movie approach to history."¹⁵

GWTW, like other silent and sound films about the war, bolstered the four-pronged presentation of the Plantation Myth that the Old South was a special place ruined forever by history's lightning: 1) all white Southerners were rich plantation owners and, in their personal lives, well-educated, romantic cavaliers; 2) white Southerners loved their slaves and their slaves loved them and they all just wanted to be left alone; 3) the North started the war, forcing the gentlemen of the South to fight the Lost Cause for four long years, to lose in the end, but lose gallantly; 4) the South was devastated by Reconstruction—imposed by the federal government—and never recovered. *Gone With the Wind*, seen by just about every American in theaters and, later, on television, had the power to reinforce these myths and turn them into acceptable fact.

The first great distortion in the book and movie, carried over from the silent-film era, was that all Southerners were wealthy, lived on huge plantations and owned hundreds of slaves (the Tarleton Twins alone owned 106). When Selznick's people researched plantation homes in northern Georgia in order to design Tara, they had to report back to him that they could not find one that was as large as Selznick envisioned Tara and Twelve Oaks or one that had white-columned

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porches. Selznick shrugged and told them to design Tara as it appeared in the movie, anyway, and call it an authentic re-creation. Once his set designers gave him Tara (they painted the exterior of Twelve Oaks on a scrim), Selznick used it as the backdrop for a society in which everyone was rich and owned slaves. He was determined, like so many before him, to re-create a Southland of mansions and elegance, even if the one in *GWTW* never existed.



The massive and elegant Tara mansion—a designer's fantasy created on Selznick's orders in the absence of any real plantation house that was sufficiently large and impressive to serve as a model for it.

The fingerprints of *The Birth of a Nation* were all over *Gone With the Wind*. Just as *Birth* opened with scrolled wording telling viewers that the Southern states constituted a separate country ("the Southland") with separate cultural ways, living by its own rules, *GWTW*

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opened with similar scrolled wording—backed up by that gorgeous Steiner theme—informing viewers that there once was a "land of cavaliers and cotton fields called the Old South"; that there, "gallantry took its last bow"; that "here was the last ever to be seen of Knights and their ladies"; and that it was really "a civilization" that was now "gone with the wind."

In this separate country with its separate rules live two families, the Wilkeses and the O'Haras, who are presented in the first few frames of the film as wealthy but benevolent, good and decent people—very much like the lovable Cameron family in *Birth*. All the trappings of strong family life are shown: parents at home loving their children, respect for their institutions, friendship between siblings, family mealtime prayers and even pet dogs who romp on Scarlett O'Hara's front porch (just as the Camerons' dogs romp in *Birth*).¹⁶ The Wilkeses and O'Haras, and the other slaveholders in the movie's Old South, are good to their slaves, who love them in return. The two families, like the Camerons, are so personable that they became very real to audiences. From the beginning of the film, viewers are cheering for them and resentful of anyone who tries to hurt them. (This opening scene of the likable family that engages in detestable practices was used with similar success in the opening wedding scene in *The Godfather*.) "You find you know these people as thoroughly as though you had lived with them for years," wrote Bosley Crowther in his rereview of *GWTW* in 1941.

Scene after scene shows reciprocal affection between slaves and masters—the film's second major distortion. "You must be gentle with darkies," Gerald O'Hara admonishes his daughters. Scarlett's mother is seen helping sick slave children. The irascible but likable Mammy sticks with the family through the war, spurning freedom, just to help them get through hard times. Big Sam is content. Even Prissy, who knows nothing about birthing babies, stays.

Many of the loving slaves are depicted as idiots or fools. Prissy's whining, witless character made any African American watching the movie cringe. Malcolm X said that of all the abuses of blacks in the film, the depiction of Prissy hurt him the most. A poll of women who watched the film showed approval for Scarlett's slapping of Prissy when the girl lies about her ability to deliver babies.¹⁷ Although the liberal Selznick had the word "nigger" cut out of the film, in the book,

characters repeatedly called each other "nigger" and the house servants sneered at the "field hands," whom they considered dumb. Southern city slaves referred to slaves on cotton plantations as "country niggers."

In the book, Melanie and Scarlett survive a kitchen fire at Tara set by Yankee soldiers (naturally). Both are covered in soot. Scarlett laughs at Melanie and tells her, "You look like a nigger." Melanie laughs back. "And you look like the end man in a minstrel show."¹⁸

In the movie's opening scenes contented slaves are picking cotton and driving wagons full of felled trees, and other such scenes abound. At the Southland's balls, parties and picnics, black servants lovingly prepare and serve food and are pleased to take the reins of their masters' guests' horses. Black girls gladly spend hours fanning the air to keep it cool while their owners' daughters take an afternoon beauty sleep. A servant braves pouring rain to chase and kill a chicken for the "white folks'" Christmas dinner. Mammy and another servant mourn, misty-eyed, that Yankee soldiers have stolen Tara's livestock. It is "a whole world that wants only to be graceful and beautiful," as Melanie Hamilton tells Ashley Wilkes, but meddling abolitionists from the North destroy it all by going to war against it.

That is the third distortion in the film. Mitchell, and then Selznick and his writers, quickly position the Northerners as the aggressors at the Wilkes barbecue early in the film, and the old formulation follows. Gerald O'Hara acknowledges that the South fired the first shot when it attacked Fort Sumter, but the movie immediately accuses President Lincoln of starting the war by calling for seventy-five thousand troops to put down the rebellion. Someone shouts that one Southerner can lick twenty Yankees. Someone else yells that gentlemen (South) can fight better than rabble (North). Another says that the Southerners can lick the Northerners in one, single battle. Rhett Butler then jumps into the conversation to warn the Southerners that the Yankees outnumber them and have a standing army and more supplies and factories to make weapons and ammunition. This immediately frames the Lost Cause for the audience, setting up the Confederates as underdogs who must fight gallantly even to stay on the field, much less win the war.¹⁹

That stated, GWTW then proceeds to show how the Lost Cause was defended for four long years in an unequal struggle against the

Union army. That is bitterly underlined by Ashley Wilkes, home on Christmas leave, when he says, "The Yankees keep coming and coming. There are always more."²⁰

Scene after scene reminds viewers of the South's hardships: hundreds gather in an Atlanta street to get the lists of dead and wounded after Gettysburg. In one of filmdom's most vivid scenes, thousands of wounded troops lie moaning in a large Atlanta square, a tattered Confederate flag flying above as a stunned Scarlett walks among them. Atlanta hospitals are filled with the dead and dying, all put there by Yankees. Atlanta itself is burned to the ground by the Yankees and the good people there are forced to evacuate like rats. ("Yankees in Georgia!" wails Aunt Pittypat. "How did they ever get in?") Tara and Twelve Oaks are razed by the Yankees. Women like Melanie Wilkes have to turn over their gold wedding rings to the Confederate army so they can be used to buy supplies for the troops. Even Belle Watling, the notorious madam, supports the cause ("I'm a Confederate like everybody else").

Gentle Southern women like Scarlett must turn into murderers to prevent Yankee soldiers from raping them. The threatened rape of Scarlett by a Union soldier at Tara, symbolically the rape of the entire South by the U.S. Army, is averted when Scarlett shoots the soldier.²¹ After killing him, Scarlett mutters that he was probably a deserter, suggesting that at heart all Yankees were cowards.²²

Honest and law-abiding citizens in Atlanta are turned into looters when Atlanta is attacked, but they are not following their own instincts. They loot, Rhett Butler insinuates, because they must have a way to save themselves from the advancing Union army.

In the end, the South is devastated by the war. With vultures overhead, Scarlett and Melanie drag themselves back to Tara, driving their carriage past dead Southern soldiers, overturned wagons and burned-out Southern homes. Scarlett's mother dies of typhoid fever she has contracted while caring for the typhoid-ridden daughters of the Slattery family, the local "poor white trash," as the good plantation women always cared for those around them, black and white. Gerald O'Hara, practically mad, breaks his neck in a riding accident (in the novel he rides recklessly after being ordered to take a loyalty oath to the Yankees so that he could keep Tara, and in the film he rides after a carpetbagger Scarlett has just denounced as a "Yankee coward"). All

of this has been caused by the Yankees. The movie conveniently overlooks the devastation wrought by Southern armies, such as the massacre of black soldiers at Fort Pillow, in Tennessee; the torching of Chambersburg, Pennsylvania; and the deaths of thousands of prisoners at Andersonville. (The death camp at Andersonville was such a touchy issue, seventy-five years after the war, that Ashley Wilkes's imprisonment at Rock Island, a Union prison in Illinois, mentioned in the novel, was snipped out of the movie to avoid raising the Andersonville issue on the Southern side.)

Southern reviewers grasped the many Plantation Myth meanings of the film immediately and hoisted it on their pens as Stonewall Jackson would have hoisted one of his Virginia cavalry flags. "The Lost Cause will never be lost," wrote a critic for the *Richmond News Leader*, "as long as there beats one heart which is pumped by one drop of southern blood . . . the real thing [history of the South] was painted for us. We wondered how the men and women of the South ever came out of that terrible tragedy alive or sane . . . [the film] was a truly great and moving experience."²³

Of course, the true success of the movie lay not in the continued advancement of the myth but in the riveting character of Scarlett O'Hara, a fierce individualist who is the ultimate survivor of a destroyed civilization. She is an independent woman who survives everything to rebuild Tara and then her own life in Atlanta, symbolic of the rebuilding of the entire South and, for Depression audiences, the United States in the 1930s. Scarlett is also a far more complex character, and more believable, than any heroine of the silent era or other 1930s Plantation Myth films. She yearns for Ashley Wilkes until nearly the end of the movie, when she finally realizes, too late, that the man she should have loved is Rhett Butler, who desperately loved her. It was Scarlett's soap opera story, full of spectacular sets and scenes and vividly drawn characters, black and white, and Clark Gable's dynamic, roguish Rhett, that made *GWTW* succeed. Women loved it for Scarlett's independence and Rhett's charms, men loved it for Rhett's manliness and all loved it for its story of survival in a war-torn world and the taut melodrama of the death of what was presented as a gracious world in simpler times.

That is why Selznick, the Hollywood producer, had loved the story, too, even if filming it meant taking a risk. He saw the book as two

interwoven stories, both highly attractive—the survival of feisty Scarlett and her friends in a war, and a love story. But he quickly realized that what was a quintessentially Southern book could not be so unequivocally a Southern movie. All the basic elements of the runaway best-seller (it sold fifty thousand copies in its first day in stores and was the number one best-seller for nearly two years) were kept in the script, but much of the book's vitriolic portrayal of Northerners was deleted, and numerous anti-Northern references were cut out. The love story between Scarlett and Rhett was highlighted in the movie, and many of the nicely drawn but clearly Southern characters were eliminated. Numerous carpetbaggers were trimmed from the story, too. Although blacks were presented in stereotypical ways, the novel's worst depictions of them were removed from the film. One black calling another "nigger" was eliminated, as was a scene where Prissy eats watermelon with great glee.²⁴

One of the biggest changes was the role of the Ku Klux Klan. In the book, Ashley Wilkes and Scarlett's husband, Frank Kennedy, are leaders of the KKK in Atlanta and lead a raid to murder blacks in retribution for an attack on Scarlett. Mitchell's most powerful defense of the Klan in the novel, and a telling scene, has Melanie Wilkes, the saintly Melanie, lying to federal officers to protect her husband and others in the KKK. In the scene, Melanie's sister India defines the role of Southern men and their women, and of the men in the Klan in particular. She tells a disbelieving Scarlett that her husband and Ashley are Klansmen and then adds, defensively: "They are men, aren't they? And white men and Southerners. You should have been proud of him."²⁵ In other words, men, Southern men, belong in the KKK.

Mitchell, and many other Southerners, saw the Klan as providing needed protection against blacks and white agitators in the 1870s—and in the 1930s, too.²⁶ "One of the earliest purposes of the Klan was to protect women and children," she wrote. "Later, it was used to keep the Negroes from voting eight or ten times at every election. But it was used equally against the Carpetbaggers who had the same bad habit where voting was concerned. Members of the Klan knew that if unscrupulous or ignorant people were permitted to hold office in the South their lives and property would not be safe. . . ."²⁷

Selznick's fear, though, was that the Klan was undergoing a strong resurgence just as *GWTW* was about to open, and he despised the

organization. The KKK had reportedly murdered or maimed dozens of people, black and white, throughout the country, North as well as South, in the spring and summer of 1939. Klansmen burned crosses in front of black homes and churches, as usual, but in the summer of 1939 they burned several as well in front of the homes of white Jews and Catholics and in front of synagogues and Catholic churches. Crosses were burned as far north as Jersey City, New Jersey. Deputy sheriffs and police officers in several Southern states publicly admitted to Klan membership; one was even a deputy sheriff in Fulton County, Georgia, where *GWTW* opened. According to Klan Imperial Wizard Hiram Evans in congressional testimony, the Klan even became involved in pressuring state transportation agencies in the awarding of contracts to pro-Klan contractors. By the time *GWTW* opened, KKK membership had soared to over three hundred thousand. Selznick did not want to help it increase further.²⁸

The Klan set up its Georgia headquarters on Peachtree Street, where Mitchell lived and where she worked as a reporter for the *Atlanta Constitution*, so she drove past their offices just about every day (her black servant refused to go with her when she was going to be around KKK headquarters).²⁹ She had no qualms about the Klan and in a letter wrote: "I had not written anything about the Klan which is not common knowledge to every southerner."³⁰ The Klan was just as much a presence in Southern life when the movie came out as it was during Reconstruction.

Selznick did not want to romanticize the Klan, as Griffith had done twenty-five years earlier. He had just turned down an offer to remake *Birth* as a sprawling, four-hour-long color epic, and he also knew the KKK would have been box office poison in the North; so the Klan and all of its robes were conveniently left on the cutting room floor.³¹ It is also probable that the Jewish Selznick remembered how *Birth* glamorized the old Klan, which harassed blacks. He did not want to glamorize the new Klan, which harassed Jews. "[I have] no desire to produce an anti-Negro film. We ought to be careful that the Negroes come out decidedly on the right side of the ledger," he told screenwriter Sidney Howard.³² And he remarked to a friend that inclusion of the KKK might make the movie "come out as advertisements for society's intolerant groups. . . ."³³

Selznick was careful not to talk publicly about leaving the Klan out

of the film beyond that statement. If Ashley and Kennedy had stayed in the Klan, moreover, it would have completely undermined the movie's portrayal of them as harmless Southern victims.

That was just one of the several subtle but significant shifts in the Plantation Myth in the film version of *Gone With the Wind*. Eliminating the Klan removed vigilantism from Southern makeup and undercut any thoughts that Southerners, or anybody, should go outside the law for justice. (Mitchell told friends that she had little to do with the making of the movie, and there is no evidence that she protested Selznick's view of the Klan.)

Selznick also gave the movie a more progressive look at Reconstruction. At first, many historians agreed that Reconstruction was unfair and harsh, but later experts, such as Eric Foner, writing in the 1970s, suggested that it was helpful and necessary. In the book *Gone With the Wind*, there is only one view of Reconstruction: it was a deliberate and aggressive campaign by Northerners to destroy economically whatever Sherman and Grant's troops had not destroyed militarily.

In the movie, Selznick significantly toned down the book's harsh portrait of *all* Northerners in Reconstruction. It is not the federal government, soldiers, or Northerners in general who are the villains, but only the vile carpetbaggers, the overly eager businessmen who invade the South as the war ends. A pair of Northern carpetbaggers in a carriage refuse to give a lift to a dying Confederate soldier being carried home by his friend. The two bedraggled soldiers, covered in dirt and grime, are cursed out as "Southern scum." Gerald O'Hara wails that only Yankee carpetbaggers and scalawags (their Southern accomplices) now have money. Well-dressed carpetbaggers tell newly freed slaves that they'll be taken care of if they vote the way the carpetbaggers tell them to. Big Sam, a freedman after the end of the war, leaves Atlanta, disgusted with the behavior of these Northern invaders, who are clearly defined as *not* representing all Northerners.

There are numerous messages in the movie, some overt and some subtle, to suggest that Reconstruction was necessary and successful. One scene shows Atlanta being rebuilt so that its people can move forward. It lasts only a few seconds, a backdrop to Scarlett and Mammy walking down a street, but it is effective. The same scene shows dozens of U.S. Army soldiers, white and black, walking about,

intimidating no one. There is a preponderance of unthreatening black soldiers. When, finally, Scarlett decides to work with the Northerners to make her new lumber business a success, Melanie argues that she is working with the same people who have ruined their world. Scarlett snaps that she will beat them at their own game. The inference is that Scarlett understands, as all should have understood, that cooperation between North and South would bring reconciliation, economic success and the rebirth of the South.

Selznick, although a prisoner of Hollywood's conventional depiction of blacks as retainers and fools, certainly gave them more character and presence than they had enjoyed in any other movie to that point. Mammy clearly runs Tara and the O'Haras feel genuine affection for her, and later, so does Rhett Butler. GWTW also clearly is not part of the "black beast" school of D. W. Griffith. Blacks are not marauding thugs, murderers, rapists or dancing fools here. Selznick took a huge step away from that idea in the scene where Scarlett rides through Shantytown and is accosted by two men, one white and one black. In the book, a freed black slave grabs Scarlett and runs his hand over her breasts while a white man grabs the horse. In the movie, a white man tries to grab her while a black grabs the horse.³⁴ It is a small scene, a swift moment in time, but it signifies a departure from the view of blacks promulgated in previous films.

Although the movie extols Southern manhood and female virtue and constantly shows the South as victim, the enemy—the North—is strangely missing. Somebody is clearly killing Confederate soldiers, somebody has won the battle of Gettysburg and somebody has fired all those shells into downtown Atlanta, but viewers never actually see the Union army doing anything. The only bluecoats who appear during the war are a few deserters, like the one Scarlett shoots. The army does not become a presence until Reconstruction, and even then its officers are portrayed as understanding. (Ward Bond, as the officer looking for Ashley, Rhett and the others one night when they stumble home pretending to be drunk, obviously knows that something is going on but chooses to do nothing.) The omission was a productive restructuring of the old lore and a new direction for Civil War films, towards an even fuller reunification.

Selznick was also determined not to star Southern actors in the movie. He went after Gable and deliberately cast British actor Leslie

Howard (who, like Gable, thought the movie would be a box office disaster) as Ashley Wilkes. Hattie McDaniel, who played Mammy, was from the Midwest (Margaret Mitchell lobbied hard, but unsuccessfully, to have Eleanor Roosevelt's White House maid play Mammy).³⁵ Howard and Leigh not only gave GWTW a more neutral look, but, as the crafty Selznick knew, guaranteed good box office for the film when it was released in England and then in Europe.

A NUMBER of films with Civil War-era themes had preceded *Gone With the Wind* in the 1930s: *Steamboat Round the Bend*, *Dixiana*, *Jezebel*, *So Red the Rose*, *Mississippi*, *The Texan*, *The Vanishing Virginian*, *The Little Colonel*, *The Littlest Rebel*, *Cotton Pickin' Days*, *My Old Kentucky Home*, *Dixie Days*, *Hearts in Dixie*, *Mississippi Gambler* and *Showboat*. Even the Three Stooges starred in their own Civil War film, *Uncivil Warriors*. Except for the highly successful Shirley Temple films *The Littlest Rebel* and *The Little Colonel*, however, most of these did only marginal business at the box office. Nonetheless, producers continued to believe that Civil War films had an audience.

These films developed an even more romantic and traditional view of the South than the Civil War silents. Southern plantation life is described nicely by Julie in *Jezebel* when she says to Pres, whom she wants to stay in the South: "Can you hear them? The night noises? The mockingbird and the magnolia? See the moss hanging in the moonlight. You can fairly taste the night, can't you? You're part of it, Pres, and it's part of you." The South is always positioned as a separate country in 1930s films.³⁶

It was a country, too, that filmmakers defined as different from other parts of America. "Its [film] iconography includes mint juleps, stately mansions with white columned porticos, landscaped lawns and gardens, and fields of cotton in which contented darkies labor. This environment connotes an agrarian economy and patrician way of life. Additional associations are the cavalier and belle, genteel customs, the code of chivalry, leisure, hospitality and faithful slaves," wrote critic Ida Jeter about the 1930s Civil War films.³⁷ W. J. Cash, writing about all Civil War movies in that era, said that they were "stage pieces out of the nineteenth century."

By the 1930s, the role of blacks in films had become so familiar to

audiences that blacks' demeaned and/or minimal status was as much a staple of American movies as the cavalry charge in the westerns, the hooker with the heart of gold, the pie-in-the-face routine of slapstick comedies and the Our Gang kids' clubhouse. After the black and white-liberal protests over the depiction of blacks in *The Birth of a Nation*, Hollywood producers were afraid to portray blacks in an unflattering light—or any light. None wanted controversy that might make the newspapers. To avoid any disputes over blacks they simply took their scissors and snipped them out of films, much as America snipped them out of daily life. Hollywood, burned badly by projecting its image of the “black beast” in 1915, would not touch the black man again in a substantial way for nearly fifty years. That retreat denied audiences a chance to view any meaningful interpretations of black life or realistic American life on the screen. After 1915, the only roles black actors could win were as butlers, servants, laborers, chauffeurs or waiters. The only way talented blacks could get into movies was to shuffle through films as Sambos or Mammies. Bill “Bojangles” Robinson got into some Shirley Temple movies and some tap-dancing duos, such as the Nicholas Brothers, and singers, such as Dorothy Dan-dridge, appeared in movies as nightclub acts. A few mainstream films about black life in the South, such as *Hallelujah!* in 1929, were made by Hollywood studios, but they were banned from many movie houses in the Southern states by local censorship boards.

Many of the actors portraying blacks in films continued to be whites working in blackface makeup, which demeaned blacks. As late as 1942, actors wore blackface in the Bing Crosby hit *Holiday Inn* (which introduced the classic song “White Christmas”). As one striking young blonde has her face blacked, she tells Crosby that she's always seen herself as pretty, and now look what she looks like (black). In effect, blacks were written out of movies.³⁸

“Previously so recognizable in literature and light theater, the black character also came to be conveniently and repeatedly present in the new medium, film. And the more often the Negro persona was used, the more often the black's lowly status was confirmed. The South in its treatment of the Negro became not only more understandable but even forgivable,” wrote Edward Campbell in 1980 in *The Celluloid South*.³⁹ A few years earlier, Daniel Leab had observed that “In the main, the black man on screen [in the 1930s] continued to

be presented as emasculated, easily frightened, semiliterate, while the black women were shown as fat, excessively jolly menials.”⁴⁰

Advertising and publicity for 1930s films were degrading to blacks. Paramount, which produced *Mississippi*, starring Bing Crosby, urged theater owners to hire blacks to sit on bales of hay in the theater lobby and play Southern tunes on a banjo. Theaters all over America featured posters showcasing the grinning Five Cabin Kids, black children who performed in the movie. The studio referred to them alternately as “darkie” children, “those Ethiopian quintuplets” and “most entertaining bits of chocolate sweetness.”⁴¹

Many of these films used the same plot device that was so effective in *The Birth of a Nation*: make the slaveholders lovable so that audiences embrace them and cheer for them. It worked. In *Jezebel*, Pres, played by Henry Fonda, spends much of the movie acting kindly towards the black slaves serving as butlers and maids in Jezebel's New Orleans mansion and on her country plantation, Halcyon. Finally, to show how much he loves them, he invites “Uncle Cato,” the friendliest slave, to have a mint julep with him. Cato, who knows his place, tells him that it would not be proper for him to be seen drinking with a white man, but, since they are such great friends, he will have the drink—but down it inside a closet.

In *The Vanishing Virginian* (1941), Leigh Whipple plays a dying slave who asks to be returned to the old plantation, where he had spent most of his life with his beloved owner, so that he can be buried under the old magnolia trees near his familiar cotton fields.⁴²

Journalists and critics were spoon-fed this theme in press releases. A PR blurb for one of the Civil War movies of the 1930s described it, typically, as “. . . the story of a proud plantation owner and his family when war clouds gather, precipitating a conflict that engulfs a peace loving people. . . .”⁴³

The publicity easily influenced critics, who looked for the message and found it. Writing about a slaveholding family in a film, one critic concluded that they “treated their slaves humanely and deserved the affection portrayed in the film.”⁴⁴

Press agents for these films worked with the United Daughters of the Confederacy to stage world premieres in Southern cities. The movie company would send the director and stars to the premiere to garner local publicity, and the UDC worked to turn out a huge crowd

THE REEL CIVIL WAR

for the premiere and the film's run in that city, building the box office with its mailing list of sixty thousand patriotic, dues-paying members and, incidentally, gilding the Plantation Myth image at the same time. One clever press agent came up with the idea of world premieres in the state capitals of each of the eleven original Confederate states.⁴⁵ Each premiere was hosted by that state's UDC leaders, all of whom got a chance to meet the movie's stars, get autographs and have a picture taken with them.

The studio publicity departments promoted these 1930s Civil War movies as historically accurate, and journalists and critics believed them. "Theatrical tradition, in its various manifestations in the past, via printed word, stage and screen, has popularized . . . Dixie galantry," wrote a critic in *Variety* in 1935.⁴⁶

One of the reasons the life presented in Civil War movies seemed authentic to so many was that by the late 1930s the Southern view and the general American view of slavery and contemporary blacks had changed. History books written in the 1920s ignored race as the most important factor in Southern history and instead said that factor was the economy. The rampaging black rapist had been ignored since the early 1920s and dismissed by historians, who were now arguing that blacks were pretty much invisible in the South, aimless children who did not have to be feared.

Black actors were seen as incompetent, as incapable of good performances—as illustrated by this studio press release: "The director [King Vidor] holds the opinion that the colored race is the most difficult of all people to handle as a group in the making of motion pictures. Fundamentally, living only for the joy they get out of life, they are inclined to laugh at serious things and this native comedy sometimes is difficult to overcome when sheer drama is necessary."⁴⁷

Although few in number, filmmakers who did rely on historians then pushed any and all black characters in Civil War films deep into the background scenes of their films, as historians did in their texts.⁴⁸

William Boehnel, a reviewer for the *Brooklyn Eagle*, notorious for his sharp-edged reviews, said about *So Red the Rose*: "It is a one sided picture, with the northern forces being made out as uncouth killers and the southerners—military and civilian alike—presented as the [essence] of self sacrifice and good breeding."

Beverly Hills, a pseudonymous critic for *Liberty* magazine, wrote

The War Comes to Tara

about *So Red the Rose* and Civil War films in general in 1935. She realized how movies had influenced Americans' view of history. "The background—crooning plantation slaves, mint julep drinking gentlemen and elegant young ladies—is painted through the misty kindness of time. Perhaps this isn't the South as it actually was, but it's a charming picture of how most of us imagine it."⁴⁹



Slaves are portrayed as unruly in *So Red the Rose*. Plantation mistress Vallette Bedford (Margaret Sullivan) uses her friendship with her workers to prevent an uprising when the Union army approaches.

So Red the Rose, released in 1935, based on Southern writer Stark Young's best-selling book (Margaret Mitchell told Young she thought his book was "marvelous"),⁵⁰ was one of the most egregiously distorted films about the lives of slaves. One of the ways in which white writers and directors strove to make Civil War movies "authentic" was to insist on slave dialect in scripts. In *So Red the Rose*, the lines of dialect

the black actors were given belittled them and made them seem a race of children. When a cannonball explodes on the plantation, a black kitchen slave shouts: "A message from Abraham Lincoln! Dat's what dat is! Abraham Lincoln done sent us a cannon ball to tell us he ain't far away!"

Later on in the film, the unruly blacks decide to revolt. Their leader, Cato, tells them to take all the livestock, and his plan is to eventually seize the plantation manor house itself. "It all belongs to us! We're the Kings! Marse Lincoln has given us de land. He has given us de houses. No more plowing . . . no more chopping wood. Just sit-tin' in the sun!"⁵¹

Newspaper critics quickly grasped, and accepted, the movie's presentation of a decent and controlled white South contrasted with its unstable black slaves. One critic wrote that the Negroes rioted in the movies only because the white man (the civilized race) was not around.⁵²

Writing about *So Red the Rose*, Arthur Draper said that if it was successful, "it will be at the cost once again of provoking even sharper racial lines than exist in these states at the present time, of provoking an even greater hatred by the whites for the negroes, of breaking the solidarity between workers of all races that is today beginning to change the Old South."⁵³

But Hollywood executives saw it another way: failure. *So Red the Rose*, despite being based on a best-seller and being given a cast of Hollywood stars and substantial publicity, did not do well at the box office. This sent a warning signal to the offices of David O. Selznick. He had paid Margaret Mitchell a large amount of money for the rights to *Gone With the Wind*, and he could not afford a similar box office flop. Perhaps because of Paramount's *So Red the Rose*, he dropped an initial idea to employ (at Mitchell's insistence) singing black field hands, and told writers to develop solid planter-slave relationships, cut out the word "nigger" and eliminate the KKK from the script. He was hopeful that Mitchell's book would turn out much better on the screen than Stark Young's.

IN HER NOVEL, Margaret Mitchell spent dozens of pages building up the idea of a gentle Old South populated by kind planters and slaves

who loved them. She wrote about the shelling and burning of Atlanta, and its evacuation by the populace, at great length, drawing a heart-stopping picture of a great city turned into rubble by Sherman's army.⁵⁴ Again and again she showed the Union Army treating Southerners with disdain. In the book, Tara is raided twice by the Union Army and just about everything the O'Haras own is stolen.⁵⁵ Mitchell explained, through characters not used in the film, why the poor farmers wisely allied themselves with the rich plantation owners. They were certain that if they worked hard they, too, could own slaves, buy large plantations and become rich.⁵⁶

She wrote scathing descriptions of Reconstruction, many of which seemed taken directly out of *The Birth of a Nation*, to show how the South was pillaged and ruined by carpetbaggers and recently freed slaves.⁵⁷ She dredged up every political, cultural and social argument she could think of to show how the Yankees had destroyed the South. She even charged that former mistresses of plantations had to wear rags while the wives of teachers from the North who were sent south to educate the former slaves wore the latest fashions.⁵⁸

Into all of these scenes, Mitchell wrote the feelings that Selznick captured on camera—those of a defeated but noble people who with great dignity try to get on in a world wrecked by Northerners for no good reason except to free their friends the slaves, who then go about behaving badly. "They were crushed and hopeless, citizens of conquered provinces," Mitchell wrote of the Southerners. "They were looking on the state they loved, seeing it trampled by the enemy, rascals, making a mock of the law, their former slaves a menace, their men disenfranchised, their women insulted."⁵⁹

No film script could capture all the drama and nuance of Mitchell's novel, but the writers for GWTW came close. They gave theatergoers a condensed yet forceful interpretation of the book and, in such a powerful medium, thus nailed down most of the legend.

It wasn't that Margaret Mitchell wanted to nostalgically glorify the Old South in *Gone With the Wind*—it was that she could not help doing so. Her entire background suggests that any book she would have written about the Civil War era would turn out to be based on the Southern view of the Old South, slavery, the war, Reconstruction and the KKK. Everything in her background, from stories she heard as a little girl to the books she chose to read, led her to write *Gone With*

the Wind exactly the way she did—giving many Americans a distinctly Southern and distinctly mythologized view of the Civil War.

Margaret Mitchell was the daughter of a middle-class lawyer whose family had lived in Atlanta for nearly a hundred years. The Mitchell family refused to flee the city when it was bombarded by Sherman's army in 1864, and offered their home as a hospital for wounded Confederate troops. Her great-aunts were marvelous storytellers who imbued Margaret with their own version of the Old South and slavery.

She grew up in a neighborhood many of whose residents had lived through the Civil War and Reconstruction (they were then in their late fifties and sixties) who filled her young ears with long, winding oral histories of their lives during that period. They complained about the deprivations of life in Atlanta during the war, the shelling by Sherman's army and the torching of the city. They went over in great detail the strategies of the Southern armies. When she was five years old, the Confederate veterans who lived in the neighborhood took her horseback-riding and, along the way, continually built up the lore of the Old South, the South they wanted the next generation to remember. That same year Mitchell, with others, hid under furniture in her home as an ugly race riot consumed Atlanta.⁶⁰

As a child, Margaret was taken to parades commemorating Atlanta's Confederate dead and was taught Civil War poems and songs (her favorite was "I'm a Good Old Rebel and That's What I Am!"). Relatives told her all they knew about the Civil War, explaining in great detail how a perfectly successful world of agrarian farmers was wrecked by the reckless Yankee abolitionists with their wrong-headed view of slavery. She was regaled with long biographical accounts of Southern Civil War-era heroes such as Jefferson Davis, Robert E. Lee, Joe Johnston, Stonewall Jackson and Georgia's own Howell Cobb. She was told about Pickett's glorious charge at Gettysburg, the defense of Petersburg, Grant's inability to beat Lee at either Cold Harbor or Spotsylvania, the valor of the defenders of Vicksburg, the Confederate rout of the federals at Bull Run and Lee's gallant stand at Antietam. On Sunday afternoons, when she visited some relatives who were veterans, she thrilled in putting her thumbs into the bullet holes in the skull of a dead Confederate soldier.⁶¹

Mitchell often reminisced to friends about where the premise of

Gone With the Wind was born and explained how her mother took her towards Jonesboro—"the road to Tara"—and showed her the old ruins of houses where, she said, "fine and wealthy people had once lived." She told her that some of the ruins dated from Sherman's visit. "And she talked about the world these people had lived in, such a secure world, and how it had exploded beneath them," she wrote.⁶² She joked to friends later that "I heard everything in the world except that the Confederates lost the war."⁶³

As a child, she was also greatly influenced by the books of Southern writers, such as Thomas Nelson Page, whose syrupy Old South/cavalier novels sold so well throughout the South in the late nineteenth century. The works of Thomas Dixon had a particularly strong impact on her; she saw *The Birth of a Nation* when she was fifteen and read *The Clansman*, *The Leopard's Spots* and *The Traitor*, all anti-black, and enjoyed them.⁶⁴ "I was practically raised on your books," she told Dixon. "And love them very much."⁶⁵

She and her childhood friends staged their own play based on *The Traitor*, playing Klansmen. In it they staged the lynching of a man, a role taken by little Margaret.

As a Southerner, Mitchell found it natural to turn to the past for heroes. She began writing *Gone With the Wind* in 1926, in the middle of another revival of the Lost Cause both North and South. In a conciliatory and surprising move, the American Bar Association published a heartwarming tribute to Robert E. Lee in 1924. That same year, with much pomp, Congress authorized a commemorative coin with Lee and Stonewall Jackson on it. One year later, Congress voted funds to fully restore Lee's Virginia mansion to its prewar splendor. In 1928, President Calvin Coolidge sent the U.S. Marine Corps band to entertain crowds gathered at several national reunions of Confederate veterans groups. In 1930, Congress voted funds to permit the placing of headstones on the graves of all Confederate veterans.⁶⁶ The commemorative trend showed up in publishing, too. In the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries there were many historical novels about heroic Confederate figures. Major nonfiction works about Southern heroes appeared as well. The 1920s and early 1930s also saw dozens of flattering books about Jefferson Davis, Robert E. Lee and other luminaries of the Confederacy. Mitchell was certainly influenced by this resurgence of interest.

Southerners, of course, never fully recovered financially from the Civil War and struggled from generation to generation in a weak economy. They had been suffering economic woes for more than six decades when the Depression, following the stock market crash of 1929, hit the nation. What they wrote during that time about Southern leaders helped readers get through their troubles. "Heroic images can direct national action, overriding . . . negative circumstances and returning the people to its sense of wholeness and identity," writes literary critic Michael Kreyling.⁶⁷

Margaret Mitchell saw herself as an Atlantan writing history about her beloved city and much-maligned South, with the mission of trying as hard as she could to defend the South against what she saw as historical inaccuracies about slavery in the nineteenth century and segregation in the twentieth.⁶⁸

Mitchell used the personalities of people she knew, or composite personalities, for her characters and then started to sketch her story. (Fearful of libel suits, she always denied that the characters were based on real people.)⁶⁹ She then plunged into historical research in order to place her characters into the middle of the Civil War and Reconstruction in the Atlanta area. She read many different histories of Georgia, the Old South and the Civil War, including works on the siege of Vicksburg, the battle of Gettysburg, the fighting at Chickamauga and the assault on Atlanta. She clipped dozens of newspaper articles about the war and read old newspapers in libraries. Her research, she said, was voluminous.⁷⁰ Since she had checked all of these details, her novel had to be historically accurate, she told friends.

Mitchell, of course, made the same mistake as do so many novelists, screenwriters and directors: they accurately describe the thin tree in front of them and completely distort the forest around it. Director King Vidor made the same claim about his Civil War film *So Red the Rose*. He insisted on authentic detail throughout the film (the effort included an exasperating search for drawings or photos of silver mint julep cups). Yet he, like Victor Fleming in *Gone With the Wind*, would produce a hopelessly distorted historical drama that he assumed was accurate because the soldiers' rifles looked right.⁷¹ This was a common practice in the making of westerns as well. Writers and directors would go to great lengths to make certain the guns and

buggies they used were authentic re-creations, ignoring the way in which the film depicted Indians.

In all of the press releases, souvenir books and programs for *Gone With the Wind*, the producers stressed the historical accuracy of the book and the movie. The writer of the souvenir book assured viewers that Mitchell had checked "thousands of historical statements for accuracy."⁷² But just about everything Mitchell had read had been written by a Southern author or reporter. There was little Northern influence in any of the books or magazine and newspaper articles she used as her references. Many of the works she accepted as accurate were, in fact, products of the moonlight-and-magnolias school of late-nineteenth-century history, the books of William Dunning, James Rhodes and others who trumpeted the virtues of the Old South.

In a 1942 letter, Mitchell recounted with great satisfaction her search for weather information related to Sherman's campaign from Tennessee into Georgia in 1864. Unable to find reliable information from history books, she used a turn-of-the-century novel, *Cease Firing*, by Mary Johnston, one of the pro-Southern writers she read as a child. There, in Johnston's novel, she found what she wanted and put it into *Gone With the Wind*. Fiction, for Mitchell, was fact.⁷³

In relying on novels about the Civil War she was relying on writers with distinctly proslavery views (one of her heroes, Page, wrote of poor whites in the South that they "worked for less than the wage of the slave without any of his incidental compensation").⁷⁴ She was assuming that the novelists had found the factual data that eluded her and used it. Often, the data were not factual. Critics who have studied romantic sagas about the Civil War by late-nineteenth-century Southern novelists have said they often made up their data. For example, John Esten Cooke, who wrote *Surry of Eagle's Nest*, a novel Mitchell claimed was one of her favorites, was unable to find the romance and glamour he wanted in his research, so he made it up. "He constructed literary models of people as toy soldiers," according to literary critic J. V. Ridgely.⁷⁵

At the time both of *Gone With the Wind*'s publication and of the film's release, there was some public criticism of Mitchell's historical inaccuracy. But Mitchell discounted this criticism because it came mainly from the Communist *Daily Worker* and black newspapers, which she said had little credibility. There was very little criticism

from the mainstream press. The movie, then, was seen by critics, journalists and the filmgoing public as an accurate historical version of events in Clayton County, Georgia, in the 1860s.

Years later, when Richard Harwell gained permission from the Mitchell family to publish a book of the author's letters, her private correspondence told a very different story. There were actually many complaints about Mitchell's accuracy in her depiction of the South, particularly of blacks, and from very reputable sources. These were never made public. One of the groups most critical of the history in *Gone With the Wind* was the Society for Correct Civil War Information, in Evanston, Illinois, run by writer and civil rights advocate Lucy Shelton Stewart.⁷⁶ Stewart was joined by an army of historical nit-pickers who found inaccuracies throughout the book: Mitchell had an opera staged in the wrong year, she had armies charging in the wrong directions, she stated, falsely, that federal soldiers looted Southern cemeteries, and so on.

Mitchell came under fire from a number of historians who wrote to inform her that she had made numerous historical errors in reporting the war, the most egregious of which was that General James Longstreet disobeyed orders from Robert E. Lee at Gettysburg.⁷⁷ Mitchell defended herself by sending critics a list of history books she had used for information, and in so doing actually exposed the weakness of her research—most of them were local history texts with a regional or political bias. Some were books by local historians, such as *Georgia: Land and People*, by Frances Letcher Mitchell; *History of the State of Georgia from 1850 to 1881*, by I. W. Avery; *Reconstruction in Georgia*, by Atlanta's C. Mildred Thompson; *Atlanta and Its Builders*, by Thomas Martin; and *The History of Georgia*, by Clark Howell. Some were heavily subjective memoirs by Southern generals, such as *Advance and Retreat*, by General John Bell Hood; *Narrative of Military Operations*, by General Joe Johnston; and *Reminiscences*, by General John Gordon. Others included Southern diaries, foremost among them *Life in Dixie During the War*, a tearjerker with a strongly partisan Georgian view by Mary A. H. Gay, of Atlanta.⁷⁸

Mitchell argued that her information had to be right because, in addition to books, she had oral histories, eyewitness accounts from Confederate soldiers and even from survivors of the siege at Atlanta.⁷⁹ She chose, of course, to ignore the personal biases of these witnesses,

their strong desire to enshrine the Stars and Bars in Southern memory. Her letters showed, too, that from the start she was determined to defend the South against seventy-five years of attack. In one letter, she sums up her view on the Civil War: "We wuz robbed."⁸⁰

She was exceedingly defensive in the face of any criticism, particularly any accusations that she was a mouthpiece for segregation ("my book was not interested in propaganda"),⁸¹ and became more defensive as the critical letters rolled in. She bristled at any attacks on her racism in the book or, later, the racism of the movie. She said these charges by African Americans were not true and were trumped up by people she referred to as "professional Negroes," or by Communists.⁸²

Finally, she admitted that *Gone With the Wind* was the Southern response to *Uncle Tom's Cabin*. She told one correspondent: "It makes me very happy to know that *Gone With the Wind* is helping refute the impression of the South which people abroad gained from *Uncle Tom's Cabin*."⁸³

She never wavered in her defense of the historical research or outlook of *Gone With the Wind*. "The history in my tale was as waterproof and tight as ten years of study and a lifetime of listening to participants would make it," she argued.⁸⁴

It was not.

Absolution for the Old South

Literature in the end came to terms with these sentiments by yielding to the South in fantasy the victory it had been denied in fact.

—Arthur M. Schlesinger Sr.

WITH THREE HOURS and fifty-two minutes of celluloid, *Gone With the Wind* helped to quash seven decades of Northern attacks upon and ridicule of the South that had forced, and kept, Southerners on the defensive. Although the North itself still allowed blacks almost no rights, it was the South that was perceived as a citadel of severe segregation and racism. In the Northern states, the South was seen as stubbornly pushing its unfair voter residency and poll tax requirements, segregating its schools, bus stations and water fountains and upholding the KKK—considered a gang of thugs by the rest of the country—as heroic figures. Northern liberal editors, such as Oswald Villard of the *Nation*, conducted long campaigns against Southern lynchings. The *Crisis*, the magazine of the NAACP, slashed away at Southern racism in every issue. The zealous anti-Catholic campaign waged in the South against the presidential candidacy of New York governor Al Smith in 1928 was decried from coast to coast. And it seemed archaic that the blue laws forbidding liquor on Sunday in most Southern states remained in place after the end of Prohibition, long after they were abandoned in the North.

Except for the works of Thomas Wolfe, there were few best-selling intellectual works written in the South in the 1920s and early 1930s (the novels of William Faulkner, which sold well later, for the most part did not do well on publication in the early 1930s). Northern critics continually referred to the South as a cultural wasteland. One of

the most notable of these critics was the *Baltimore Sun* columnist H. L. Mencken; in 1917 he published a long essay, "The Sahara of the Bozart," in which he charged that the South had no historians, novelists, scientists, critics or composers worthy of note. "Down there . . . a poet is now almost as rare as an oboe player, a drypoint etcher or a metaphysician."¹ Mencken (and others) also satirized the deeply fundamentalist religious beliefs of many Southern sects—he labeled the South the Bible Belt and then, mockingly, the Hookworm Belt, the Malaria Belt and the Chastity Belt. Southern traditionalists felt so beleaguered that in 1930 twelve writers banded together and produced a book of essays, *I'll Take My Stand: The South and the Agrarian Tradition*, which defended the history and way of life of the South.

The South was a frequent target of the national press, too, and five different journalists between 1923 and 1930 won Pulitzer Prizes for crusading articles and article series unmasking segregation and other Southern institutions. Northern writers and speakers and Hollywood screenwriters had combined to create a pathetic image of the Southern states. Many general-interest novels and movies depicted the Southerners of the 1930s as strikers and strikebreakers, moonshine producers and deliverers, cranky sharecroppers, illiterate tobacco farmers and ill-bred, ill-mannered blue-collar workers. Not only did Georgia novelist Erskine Caldwell's *Tobacco Road* become a runaway best-seller and successful play, but its title quickly came to symbolize the American view of the South.

Nothing held the South up to ridicule as much as the infamous Scopes evolution trial of 1925. The case against John Scopes, a part-time science teacher in a Tennessee school, was quickly dubbed "the monkey trial" by Mencken. Hundreds of journalists from all over the United States poured into tiny Dayton, Tennessee, to cover the trial, which featured fundamentalist champion William Jennings Bryan, arguing against the teaching of evolution in schools, and Clarence Darrow, defending it. Darrow called Bryan to the stand and made his defense of the Bible sound so silly and laughable even the Southern backers of Bryan and his cause joined in the laughter. The international coverage of the trial defined Southerners as stubborn, unthinking, Bible-thumping dolts, stuck forever in the past, living in small towns up in the hills and firing potshots at wandering tax collectors.²

Northern press attacks reached a zenith in the 1930s with the vari-

ous trials of the "Scottsboro Boys." Nine young black men were charged with raping two white women on a train car in Scottsboro, Alabama, in 1931, found guilty by an all-white jury and sentenced to die. As the verdicts were announced, an all-white crowd outside the courthouse energetically sang "There'll Be a Hot Time in the Old Town Tonight." Northern lawyers defended the young men in a succession of trials after appeals courts repeatedly threw out the case on the grounds that the all-white jury had not been impartial. One of the two alleged victims recanted her story, and the young men, after long delays, were finally freed. The trials of the blacks, guilty only of their color, became a cause célèbre among Northern liberals, and for years the trial came to symbolize the backward, hateful segregationist views of all Southerners.³

A 1938 federal report said that the major problem facing the United States as the decade neared its end was the forlorn economy of the Southern states.

The South's defenders, unlike their ancestors, were no longer defending just the institution of slavery. The entire culture of the South was under fire and Southerners seemed to be racing from attack to attack, like people trying to put out hundreds of forest fires at the same time.

One of the first Southern defenders was Edwin Mims, a professor at Vanderbilt University, in Tennessee, who went on record immediately after the Scopes trial as a crusader for Southern progress. In many articles he insisted that the South was not as culturally depressed or segregationist as Northern writers had painted it during and after the Scopes trial. In articles such as "The South Pleads for Just Criticism" and "Intellectual Progress in the South," and a book, *The Advancing South*, Mims tried to show what he felt were the South's best faces.⁴

Another staunch champion was writer Donald Davidson, who saw the South as a distinctive region that could not be held to Northern standards and therefore was being assaulted unreasonably. "The northern press, with the southern press which takes its cue from New York . . . unanimously agreed that the South [was] guilty of numerous crimes against progress," he wrote in 1933. "Wherever they went with their missions of social justice . . . they carried with them a legend of the future, more dangerously abstract than the legend of the past."⁵

It was hard for these and other ardent cheerleaders, who included many newspaper editors, to cover up the genuine lack of modernization and cultural advancement in the region, even though their cause was helped by the fact that critics of the South, in the South, did not fare well. Several free-spirited, critical university professors were fired. (Deans too, such as Dr. Carl Taylor at North Carolina State, were dismissed.) One journalist, Clarence Cason, who wrote an indictment of the South, *90 Degrees in the Shade*, was fearful of how Southerners would treat him after publication of the book.⁶

The defenders of Southern culture always held their ground, despite attacks, and many felt they were treated badly over the years. "We went from history that celebrated the South, if in a defensive way, to the South as the citadel of the Devil, a place you couldn't say anything positive about without being denounced as a racist," said historian Eugene Genovese in the 1970s, in commenting on the way the South was described in the 1920s and 1930s. "The fact is that the South embodies much that's at the core of Western Christian civilization. If it has become at times the embodiment of the worst of that tradition, it has also embodied the best."⁷

Ordinary Southerners felt the same way. They saw themselves as residents of a struggling region constantly belittled by Northerners who did not understand the economic troubles they faced and their seemingly impossible problem with African Americans. Sociologist John Dollard lived in the South in the mid-1930s so that he could observe the region's culture and social system at firsthand. He reported his findings in his book *Caste and Class in a Southern Town*. The townspeople in his Southern community were racists and saw all who defended blacks as hopeless "nigger lovers." They told him that on visits to Northern cities they were disgusted when they saw blacks and whites riding the same trains and walking the same sides of the streets. The overwhelming majority complained that Northerners did not understand that Southern whites tried to be good to their blacks, but that no one appreciated their efforts.⁸ Dollard also found that whites both North and South saw blacks as unmotivated, inhabitants of not only a lower class, but a useless lower class.⁹ (This belief held firm despite studies in which employers at Northern factories said their black workers were not incompetent and, in fact, that their work was quite satisfactory.)¹⁰ Southerners had lived through the 1920s and

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1930s with certain problems and anxieties and wanted someone, somehow, to tell them that it was perfectly all right to feel the way they did, that they were good people whom history had treated unfairly and who were victims of unjust current criticism based on historically wrong assumptions.

Gone With the Wind finally did just that in the late 1930s. The ridiculous images of Southerners which so offended residents of the



*An overriding theme in *Gone With the Wind* is the close friendship between the O'Haras and their slaves. Here, Scarlett grasps the hand of Big Sam, her faithful field hand, who is on his way to dig ditches to help the Confederate army defend Atlanta against Union forces.*

Southern states were washed away in a minute by the publication of Mitchell's book. It transformed Southerners into considerate landed gentry who were kind to blacks, prayed at meals, read the great books

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and helped give America its rich agrarian way of life. The book and film changed Northerners' view of the South, replacing the moonshine-truckers-and-nymphomaniac-mountain-girls image of the 1930s with wonderful people like Scarlett O'Hara and Melanie Wilkes and heroic rogues like Rhett Butler from another generation. In *Gone With the Wind*, Margaret Mitchell influenced all Americans—especially as the film version appeared in theaters and, later, on television—and gave the South back its culture and its pride. In doing so, however, she reinforced the shackles that already gripped African Americans so tightly.

The book seemed to absolve whites in the 1930s of guilt for their insistence on white supremacy. It showed audiences that whites of all descriptions—low, middle and upper class—could get along, although this usually meant they were working together to hold black men and women down. Southern historian W. J. Cash wrote that the poor white attached himself to the wealthy white, whether in the plantation society of the 1850s or the textile mill society of the 1930s, because they were all white. By attaching himself politically, socially and culturally, a poor man became, in a sense, part of the rich white culture, leaving his own low, degraded state to the only people left to take it—the blacks. This system, in place from the 1870s on, enabled rich whites in the South to assume power and wealth as long as they somehow psychologically carried the rest of the whites along. They made the poorer ones feel that they were related somehow—distant cousins of a sort—and had to band together against the blacks to succeed.

Cash, who had his critics, also wrote that since farmers did not do slaves' work, they had nothing to fear from slaves unless slaves were suddenly free. Then poor farmers needed the protection of the politicians and the rich whites to defend them against black encroachment. Poor white people did not want blacks taking their jobs, joining their churches or, worst of all, sleeping with their women. Teaming up with rich, politically powerful whites seemed a way of maintaining racial barriers and keeping blacks in their "place."¹¹ That was the key to the growth of the monolithic, all-powerful Democratic Party in the South, which could guarantee white supremacy with its voting blocs in the House and Senate. Southern legislators agreed to approve various bills important to Northerners as long as no one touched the black-white division that had grown up in the South.

THE CRITICAL RESPONSE to the film *Gone With the Wind* from the press and leaders of civic groups was decidedly mixed—and divided by race. Mainstream white critics enjoyed the film. Some did find the portrayals of the slaves offensive and some still harped about two British actors as stars of the film. But overall, white critics appreciated the dramatic sweep of the film and the powerful characterizations. Reviewers for black publications did not enjoy it. While they felt that blacks were certainly better represented in the movie than in those that went before, they complained that white filmmakers still categorized them as Mammies, butlers and whining nannies.

The heads of black organizations were highly critical of *Gone With the Wind* when it opened. The film was picketed by more than one hundred blacks at its Chicago premiere¹² and later at its Washington, D.C., opening.¹³ A group of blacks, led by several attorneys, tried unsuccessfully to have the movie banned from theaters in Canton, Ohio.¹⁴ Reviewers for black newspapers condemned it. "[A] weapon of terror against black America," wrote a critic in the *Chicago Defender*. "Distorted and twisted history of an era." A reviewer for the *Pittsburgh Courier* wrote that the blacks in the film were "happy house servants and unthinking, hapless clods."¹⁵

African-American civic leaders saw the film undercutting the considerable and sometimes successful efforts they had made through the 1930s towards marshaling white support for integration. "Whatever sentiment there was for federal anti-lynching laws evaporated during the *Gone With the Wind* vogue," said Walter White, secretary of the NAACP.¹⁶

Most reporters and reviewers in the mainstream press, however, found little to fault; there was not even criticism of Hattie McDaniel as the prototypical Mammy who had appeared in so many Civil War silent films, magazine ads for cereals and syrups and cartoons (screenwriter Howard, in describing how she should look, was direct: she should be "aged and mountainous").¹⁷

The *New York Times* said it was simply "the greatest motion picture mural we have seen." The New Orleans *Times-Picayune* called it "decply moving" and "tremendously effective."¹⁸

Critics accepted on good faith the publicity release assertions that

the film was historically accurate and that it gave theatergoers an honest, authentic look at the entire South of the 1860s. One Richmond critic nodded knowingly and wrote that the treatment of blacks in the film was "in accord with all the stories and legends of slavery time Negroes."¹⁹ Elderly Confederate veterans who saw it told reporters that it was all true.²⁰

Surprisingly, although black newspapers criticized *Gone With the Wind*, their attacks were not as harsh as they had been about *Birth* and, after initial reviews, criticism abruptly stopped. Black critics and editors were then caught in the middle of the struggle to integrate movies. It was a racist movie and it portrayed blacks badly, but it did at least have some substantial black roles, particularly Mammy. It arrived at the end of a decade that had seen blacks make inroads into mainstream Hollywood films. African-American actors appeared in a number of movies and, while their roles were often small ones or stereotyped, they were at least getting work and opening studio doors. Some movies that used black actors were *The Prisoner of Shark Island*, *The Petrified Forest*, *Crooks*, *Of Mice and Men*, *Green Pastures*, *Fury* and *They Won't Forget*, plus a string of films with Bill "Bojangles" Robinson. The black press did not want to risk closing that avenue with a hard campaign against GWTW.

Sensing a chance both to push black equality in films and to mute any criticism of racism in GWTW, Selznick's public relations department waged a long and successful campaign to have Hattie McDaniel win an Oscar for her performance as Mammy. Some black critics urged McDaniel to turn down the award to protest the racism of the movie and the lack of work for blacks in Hollywood, but she accepted it, and did so in a gracious and well-received speech.²¹ Who could protest a movie for which a likable black actress had won an Oscar?

McDaniel understood that progress toward racial equality in film and in the United States overall was likely to be slow. The actress, who participated in several marches for housing equality for blacks in the late 1940s, considered recognition for African-American actors important, regardless of the roles they had to take. When a black activist protested her portrayal of Mammy, she responded: "I'd rather play a maid than be one."²²

There were some newspapers that denounced the movie, such as

the *Daily Worker*, but as a Communist publication it was paid little attention at the time.²³ Some members of the New York Film Critics Association who believed it was a racist movie formed a bloc and, in their votes for Best Film of 1939, managed to defeat *Gone With the Wind* and steer the prize to *Wuthering Heights*.²⁴

Criticism of the movie began to seep into the pages of newspapers, magazines and books by the late 1940s, but in a still basically segregated America it was not much heeded. "The most gigantic milestones to Hollywood's appeal to public patronage have been anti-Negro pictures like *The Birth of a Nation* and *Gone With the Wind*," said veteran screenwriter Dalton Trumbo in 1948.²⁵ "American filmmakers have concentrated on whitewashing the South . . . northern 'nigger lovers' were the villainous destroyers of the Old South and its glorious traditions," wrote film historian Peter Noble.²⁶

It wasn't until much later, following the civil rights movement of the 1960s and 1970s, that critics in the mainstream press began to see



Hattie McDaniel—here in a scene with Vivien Leigh as Scarlett—won an Oscar for giving a bit of humanity to Mammy in *Gone With the Wind*.

the complete racial distortions and mythmaking in *Gone With the Wind*. Armed with hundreds of studies of slavery and race relations over the years, a number of them finally commented on the racism of the movie.

"The black roles are deplorable . . . falsifications. Not true to southern experience. The movie refuses to show the lives of black people away from the white people they worked for . . . it's a fairy tale, an ugly fairy tale," said historian Don Boyle in 1989.²⁷

Some in the South saw *GWTW* and other 1930s Civil War films as creating unfair stereotypes of white Southerners, too. One was W. E. Debnam, a white radio broadcaster, who said they "painted the South as a backwards land peopled in the main by low-browed hoodlums smelling of lavender and old lace and sniffing away on magnolia blossoms and shuffling along a street with a mint julep in one hand and a bullwhip in the other going someplace to lynch a Negro."²⁸

In the 1990s, critics of Mitchell's book zeroed in on the ways in which she compared slaves to animals. Jim Cullen, in *The Civil War in Popular Culture*, saw a "malignant resonance" in her descriptions of slaves, citing her sketch of Jeeves, of whom Mitchell wrote that he accompanied the Tarleton Twins everywhere, like their dog. Cullen also criticized Mitchell for giving Big Sam "huge black paws" for hands, describing a black living in postwar Shantytown as "a gorilla," writing that Mammy had a "monkey's" face and, late in the book, calling her an "ape."²⁹

The same kind of demeaning portrayal was evident in the film. An example is the lines in which Prissy tells Scarlett that Tara might be under siege: "Dey's fightin' at Jonesboro. They say our gempmum's is gittin' beat. What'll happen ter maw and paw effen dey gits ter Tara?"³⁰

Mitchell always defended her slave dialect. She said that slaves spoke that way in 1859 and should be depicted as speaking that way in 1939.³¹ Her defenses of her dialect, though, showed the views she, like most Southerners, carried all her life. Fed up with criticism of black dialect, she shot back in a letter that underlined that view: "I scoured the back country of this section, routing out aged old darkies who were born in slavery days [for it]."³²

She received complaints that the dialect set up her blacks as racial stereotypes just as badly as the "Uncle Remus" stories of Joel Chan-

dlar Harris. She blithely retorted that both the son and grandson of Joel Chandler Harris had read the book and told her they enjoyed the black dialect.³³

Then, in one off-handed remark in a letter, she bragged that "the negroes have read it . . . in large herds."³⁴

Critics of *GWTW*'s and other films' depiction of blacks feared that the effect of the celluloid racism would carry far beyond the last rows of the darkened theaters, and they were right. "What Hollywood thinks of the American Negro is best expressed by the roles given him in the motion pictures," wrote Arthur Draper, who added that film-dom's portrayals were "viciously antagonistic," and a "libelous presentation of southern negroes of the Civil War period."

GWTW SUCCEEDED because it appealed to audiences of the late 1930s and early 1940s who yearned for simpler times and a place of their own. The idea of the land as something very valuable and lost comes early in the film, when Gerald O'Hara, gesturing with his hand toward the vast expanses of his plantation at Tara, tells his daughter Scarlett that the land is "the only thing in the world that matters."³⁵ Viewers saw in *GWTW* a wonderful world that would never be again and yearned for it.³⁶ That desire to go back to a world of farms and country lanes appeared often in other successful films of the Depression era and in the works of John Ford and Frank Capra. MGM's *The Wizard of Oz*, which also debuted in 1939, offered a safe farm world in Kansas which Dorothy, tossed about by a tornado, and her audience, tossed about by the Depression, thought of as home ("There's no place like home").³⁷

GWTW also succeeded because, first and foremost, it was a woman's book written by a woman, and it was a woman's film. From the very first scene to the final wail, it is the story of the whirlwind that is Scarlett O'Hara. It is her saga, her soap opera, her love story, her vanquished people, her rebirth, her individualism and her struggle. In *Scarlett*, women saw a little bit of themselves, whether it was a teenage girl teasing the boys as Scarlett teased the Tarleton Twins or an unhappy married woman churning inside about her inability to find love. Women who saw that movie identified with Scarlett and empathized with her misfortunes as they reveled in her triumphs.

Although about 25 percent of the women in America worked during the late 1930s and women had voted since 1920, they were still constrained, shackled by their role in the family and in society. Scarlett was the hellcat inside each of them. They dared not talk like Scarlett, dress like Scarlett, flirt like Scarlett or behave like Scarlett, and so they loved Scarlett for expressing their unspoken feelings.

Margaret Mitchell created Scarlett as an archetypical Southern belle. Then the character was revised by directors Victor Fleming and George Cukor and the screenwriters who worked on the movie. She fit the pattern of every belle out of Southern literature in that her charms, and not her looks, drew men to her. The first line of *Gone With the Wind*, the book, tells the reader that "Scarlett O'Hara was not beautiful, but men seldom realized it when caught by her charm." In novel after novel, Southern belles had been described just that way by different authors. It was thought that they needed to look plain so that all the plain-looking girls who bought the books could attach themselves to the belle and win their man, as their heroines did, without good looks.³⁸

The masterstroke for Scarlett's portrayal on film came from Selznick himself. He made Scarlett beautiful, just as every woman wanted to be. She became the Old Southern belle turned independent woman turned beauty queen turned businesswoman. Scarlett had it all, except for one great flaw: she loved the wrong man and ignored the right man, which meant she lost happiness. That made her vulnerable and allowed the world to embrace her. Selznick then took that symbolic Southern beauty and made her a fierce, independent woman—even an opportunist—which then drew in a second audience that admired Scarlett—the postsuffrage, politically involved women who were buying books about successful women, voting for FDR because of Eleanor Roosevelt and flocking to films starring women such as Joan Crawford, Bette Davis and Katharine Hepburn.

HOLLYWOOD DID not know how to handle the Great Depression. Studios did not want to present the Depression as it was, in all of its spreading economic horror, to a people already reeling from its effects. People had to live hand-to-mouth every day, with more than a quarter of the population out of work and millions of others forced to

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work part-time or for severely reduced wages. They did not want to see their sad day all over again at night on a movie screen. If Hollywood felt it could not produce films that honestly depicted the Depression, what could it produce?

The motion picture industry certainly addressed the Depression in some films, such as *The Grapes of Wrath*, *Dead End* and a string of gangster movies, but it also produced a large number of escapist entertainment stories. If in the 1920s people went to the movies to be entertained, they went in the 1930s to escape the reality that was engulfing them. Studios began to produce escapist films that satisfied the public's need for fantasy. There were several successful genres: 1) gangster films, 2) shyster films, about society's corruption, 3) sex,



The key to the success of Gone With the Wind was the romance between Rhett and Scarlett, here saying goodbye.

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4) cartoons, 5) westerns, 6) musicals, 7) screwball comedies and 8) Shirley Temple films.

Will H. Hays, head of Hollywood's censorship office, proudly proclaimed that Hollywood had done its job during the 1930s. "No medium has contributed more greatly than the film to the maintenance of the national morale during a period defined by revolution, riot and political turmoil in other countries," he said. "It has been the mission of the screen, without ignoring the serious social problems of the day, to reflect aspiration, optimism and kindly humor in its entertainment." No film did that like *Gone With the Wind*.

Gone With the Wind was an inspirational movie for theatergoers who watched Scarlett O'Hara go through a Civil War, almost losing her life and her home, and survive. Many unemployed men and women, some who stood on breadlines and others who stole bread to feed their families, felt their pulses race at the end of Part One when, before a blood-red sky, Scarlett stands outside her ruined Tara and, shaking a fist at God, shouts that she'll never be hungry again.

Gone with the Wind was escapist, a finely woven, wonderful soap opera and a rich love story, but it was most importantly a film about the survival of a tough woman trying to keep home and family together in the middle of turmoil. It tapped into the two most cherished beliefs of the American people: that hardworking individuals can succeed and that the family inevitably will triumph.

Audiences loved Scarlett's gritty determination not only to survive the war, using all of her wiles to do it, but also to rebuild Tara, the symbolic home for everyone in the audience, and to somehow establish the normal family life that eluded her. Scarlett's victory over financial hardship was the hoped-for victory of all economically wounded Americans who saw the film, but her inability to find sustenance and happiness in the love of a husband and a family was also a victory for those in the audience. The American people might be out of work, losing their homes and wearing shoes with holes in their soles, but at least they had loving families. Scarlett did not. So as long as they were rich in those things, and rich in spirit, they would make it. They would survive the Depression just as Scarlett survived the war.

Many men of that time saw in the woes of the movie's soldiers their own woes. They felt as wounded and helpless as the Confeder-

ate regiments.³⁹ The unemployed man, head of his household and the person relied on by all others to support the family, felt emasculated by the Depression. He could not work and take care of his family, just as the wounded soldiers could not take care of their family—the Old South.

The movie tied in to all the anxieties audiences felt in 1939. It was that anxiety, that fear, that held America in a vicious and deadly grip throughout the decade. (Roosevelt understood that as soon as he took office and warned the people that the only thing they had to fear was fear itself.) There was a bewilderment, too, in the movie, and it was somehow comforting.⁴⁰ Southerners did not understand what was happening to them. All they wanted to do was move along through the years in this peaceful life they had made for themselves, yet Northerners forced them into a war. The end of the war did not bring peace, but an economic war waged on the South by the North. In the 1930s Americans wondered: How could the Depression continue when so many wealthy people continued to prosper? How could little businesses fail on a daily basis when big businesses thrived? How could a noble and well-intentioned federal government and a visionary and experienced leader, Roosevelt, fail to bring them out of their economic nightmare?

There were dozens of grim labor strikes across the country that shook all Americans, not just the workers involved in them. Workers went on strike against their plant managers, angry that their wages were too low or had been slashed and irate, too, that many factories belonged to absentee owners who did not care about their employees. Striking workers were killed in picket lines and others were beaten by security guards. Many factories cut production from seven days a week to just three or two, and furloughed their workers. Wages were slashed as business revenues plunged and many factory workers saw their weekly pay drop from a paltry eight dollars a week to just three dollars. Real unemployment in some areas, particularly the Southern coal mine region of Tennessee and Kentucky, was much worse than public figures indicated. There, workers would be technically employed but in fact worked only a few days a month.⁴¹ Because the mines, like the mills, tended to be the only business in a town, the towns and their people started to die because there was no other

work. In April 1931, a newspaper estimated that nearly five thousand people in one coal community in the Cumberland Valley were starving.⁴² The Depression hit the South harder than any other region in the country.

Northerners wondered how Margaret Mitchell had been able to anticipate the Depression of the mid-1930s with such insight. The novel included long conversations about the “depression” of Reconstruction and the anxiety people felt in the South in the 1860s and 1870s, and yet she wrote most of her book between 1926 and 1929, before the stock market crash (the author was unhappy with the book at first and let it sit in her home for several years before making some changes and finally handing it to a Macmillan editor in 1935).

The Southern states were wounded badly in the 1920s when the huge cotton market began to collapse. A boll weevil epidemic in the 1920s severely cut back cotton production. At the same time, foreign nations began to import cotton from other markets and opened their own cotton mills, cutting into the South’s export business. In 1927, the South exported 11 million bales of cotton. By 1932 that number had been cut to just 8.7 million, by 1938 to 5 million, and in 1939, when *Gone With the Wind* premiered, to an all-time low of just 3.3 million bales.⁴³

The drop in the cotton market meant that towns that had grown up around the textile mills in the South, in the heart of the Cotton Belt, suddenly turned into slums as many of their workers were laid off. This happened in the mid-1920s, before the stock market crash of 1929. Strikes began as early as 1929, before the autumn crash. In March and April of that year there were major strikes at mills in Greenville, South Carolina; Elizabethtown, Tennessee; and Marion, North Carolina.

Lawlessness increased all over the nation as the Depression settled in, but nowhere was it as problematic as in the South. In 1937, for example, the murder rate in New England was 1.3 murders per 100,000 residents, but in the South it was 23.7 murders per 100,000. Many Americans began to think that the United States was simply going to collapse upon itself. There was talk of revolution in many places. As the number of the unemployed grew, the prospect of a civil war in the streets, akin to the civil war in *Gone With the Wind*, esca-

lated. This was particularly true in the South, where there was fear that an endless Depression would turn into a war between poor blacks and poor whites for whatever jobs existed.

But many who saw the movie considered it a sterling reminder that if people could retain their fierce individualism, just like Scarlett, they could conquer the Depression.

Readers' identification with the Depression was solid in 1936, but when the movie came out in the winter of 1939–1940, and was rereleased later in 1940 and in 1942, that identification was compounded by the anxiety over World War II. *Gone With the Wind* was a movie about the anxiety over the Civil War on the Southern homefront. Just three months before it opened in 1939, the German army invaded Poland. Polls showed that many Americans did not yet want to become involved in World War II,⁴⁴ but worried that the country would be dragged into it.

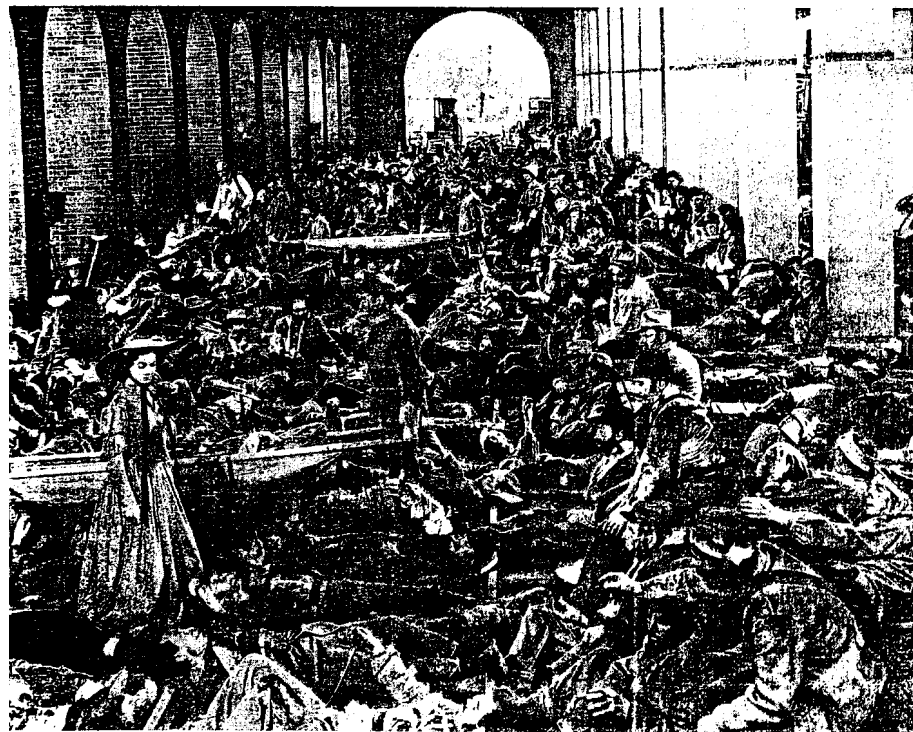
These fears of war connected perfectly with *GWTW*. Men watching the movie in 1939 and 1940 could envision themselves as the dead or wounded Confederate soldiers and women saw themselves in the scenes in which Melanie and Scarlett, wives of soldiers, waited for the lists of dead and wounded to be handed out.

Only some twenty years removed from World War I, which had devastated the European landscape, many Americans feared that World War II would result in the destruction of their country. In the summer of 1942, Atlanta's civil defense directors scheduled a simulated nighttime bombing raid on the city. They called for a 10 p.m. blackout and then had planes "bomb" the downtown area with bags of flour to show residents how widespread damage might be. As the bags of flour hit, civil defense workers set off a thousand firecracker-style explosions to create the sounds of an attack.⁴⁵ Apprehension grew after the war began, and fear of air attacks was so high that in 1943 the *Atlanta Journal*, the leading newspaper of Atlanta (the fictional setting of *Gone With the Wind*), ran several pages of pictures of destroyed European cities with headlines and captions that suggested that Atlanta might look just like that if it was bombed and that bombing was a very real possibility: DEATH, HORROR AND DESTRUCTION COULD SMITE ATLANTA ANY DAY: BOMBERS FROM HOSTILE CARRIERS MIGHT EASILY STRIKE AND ESCAPE, THIS MIGHT HAVE BEEN ON WEST PEACHTREE, THEY MIGHT HAVE DONE THIS TO GEORGIA TECH.⁴⁶

The burning of Atlanta, in the 1940s just as in 1864, seemed a very real possibility. West Coast residents shared the fear. People in Los Angeles were afraid that the Japanese, who had been able to cross an ocean to bomb Pearl Harbor, would bomb California next.

Such destruction was already a reality for people in Britain, where *GWTW* was often shown from 1940 to 1944. The German Luftwaffe was raining nightly death and destruction on British cities as early as 1940. Residents witnessed scenes similar to the burning of Atlanta and looked out on charred and ruined cityscapes, just like those of Georgia as depicted in *GWTW*.

There were legends about the London bombing. The story of Mrs. E. M. Bloomfield, of Coventry, England, was typical. She and friends



A troubled Scarlett walks among hundreds of wounded Confederate soldiers lying in a makeshift hospital at an Atlanta railroad station. The graphic scene made an easy connection to World War II, already underway in Europe when *Gone With the Wind* was released.

had just arrived to see *GWTW* when a bomb hit the theater and blew it up. Bloomfield and her friends survived the collapse of the building by crawling under their seats. Elsie Kingdom managed to see the entire film at a London theater and was talking to a friend about the burning of Atlanta when the two women emerged from the lobby and saw the city and its docks on fire from another German air raid. Another woman, Doris Marston, had to scurry to the cellar of the theater where she was watching *GWTW* when bombs started to fall (she didn't see the last half of the movie until the late 1960s).

On the homefront, women readily identified with the women of *GWTW* whose men were off fighting in the Civil War. "In times fraught with danger and suffering with the shortage of all but the bare necessities it was easy to feel a kinship with the families in the South and it was not difficult to understand Scarlett's determination 'never to go hungry again,'" said Gila Wilding.⁴⁷

But why did the film *Gone With the Wind* remain so popular after the 1930s and the end of World War II?

It succeeded for many of the same reasons as *The Grapes of Wrath*, *Citizen Kane* and *The Godfather*. When a nation has economic woes a film like *The Grapes of Wrath* or *GWTW* taps into human feelings about them. (Is there any fundamental difference between a bank taking over small farms in the 1930s and contemporary conglomerates downsizing and laying off workers?) Charles Foster Kane may be dead, but every generation has a rich and powerful person—think Bill Gates or Donald Trump—whose wealth and oversized personality intrigue people. Michael Corleone died (it took three movies, but he finally died), yet immigrants who come to America still find no true justice and often must turn to criminal organizations, such as Russian and Asian gangs, to obtain it.

GWTW was rereleased as a feature film in 1967 and did well. Why? It hit theaters on the heels of the Civil Rights movement and during a year when race riots exploded in many of America's largest cities, and so it touched off all the same controversies over race. The rerelease also came at a time when the Vietnam War was starting to divide America, and as a Civil War saga the film presented that same feeling of anxiety and trepidation. It was rereleased at a time when the United States was undergoing perhaps its greatest generational divisions, as battles over race relations and the Vietnam War drove a

wedge between parents from the World War II era and their activist children, much as the Civil War divided families. *Gone With the Wind* was shown on television for the first time in 1976 and drew record ratings. Why? Americans were still angry about Vietnam. And by the mid-1970s soap operas dominated American television, and there was no greater soap opera than *Gone With the Wind*. Americans, battling high inflation, were again living through uneasy economic times. The government of the 1970s, having just weathered the Watergate scandal, seemed as divided as it was in the late 1850s. The 1976 rerelease also came at a time when the women's movement was picking up speed, and contemporary women embraced the emancipated Scarlett.

It remains a powerful movie because of its finely acted characters, sumptuous color, heroic music, soap opera plot and mythology about the American Way. Add the yearning it generated for simpler times and a bygone way of life, and the gargantuan story of troubled lovers caught in the greatest catastrophe of the nineteenth century. These are reasons enough to make any film powerful. Since its 1939 premiere, *Gone With the Wind* had earned much criticism for its muddled history and racism. Did Americans really care?

Frankly, my dear, they didn't give a damn.